

# The Discipline of Not Knowing

What a divided decision at the Federal Reserve asks of us

BY THE PHILOSOPHY OF NOW | PRACTICAL PHILOSOPHY FOR THE DAILY LIFE

*“The mature response to uncertainty is neither panic nor pose. It is attention, followed by a proportionate act.”*

ON UNCERTAINTY, JUDGMENT, AND THE TEMPTATION TO PRETEND

At two o'clock on Wednesday afternoon, a sentence from Washington became a small weather system. The Federal Reserve held its benchmark interest rate where it was, in a range of 3.5% to 3.75%. In itself, a pause. But the vote was 9-3: three officials wanted a quarter-point increase. The report of the decision carried the familiar abstractions - inflation, borrowing, oil, growth - into kitchens, car dealerships, payroll offices, and the unquiet rooms where people decide whether they can afford to wait.

A central bank is an institution built to make grave choices before the evidence is complete. It cannot wait for certainty; by then the bill has often arrived. Yet it must not confuse urgency with knowledge. The three dissenting votes made the pause more honest, not less. They showed that the same facts can place reasonable people on different sides of a threshold. That is not a failure of seriousness. Sometimes it is

seriousness made visible.

This is the tension beneath much of modern life: we want a clear signal, while reality offers a moving field of partial signals. A supervisor asks for the forecast. A parent asks whether a change of school is right. A doctor asks whether the next test is worth the cost. A friend asks, late at night, what they should do. We hunger for the decisive voice because decisiveness seems kinder than doubt. But certainty offered too cheaply is not kindness. It is often only anxiety wearing a uniform.

The poet John Keats gave this difficulty a useful name: negative capability. He admired the capacity to remain among uncertainties and mysteries without reaching irritably for fact and reason. The phrase can sound like an invitation to vagueness. It is the opposite. To stay with uncertainty is hard

work. It requires us to distinguish what we know from what we fear, what is likely from what is merely loud, and what needs a decision now from what can still be watched.

The Federal Reserve's choice is not a parable with a guaranteed moral. Interest rates affect real people unevenly, and elevated prices can wound households already tight on money. So can higher borrowing costs. The point is not that waiting is always wise. The point is that a responsible decision can acknowledge the unfinished character of its reasons. A pause, especially one marked by dissent, is not necessarily indecision. It can be a decision to keep learning at full attention.

That distinction matters far from the marble buildings of finance. Consider the email drafted in anger. It feels urgent because the body has mistaken activation for necessity. Negative capability asks for a small delay: name the injury, gather the missing fact, sleep before sending. Or consider a career move. Instead of demanding an answer to the whole future, we can ask a smaller and truer question: what experiment would produce better evidence? A conversation, a trial project, a course, a month with the calendar cleared enough to notice what actually gives energy.

There is courage in a bounded commitment. We do not have to choose between omniscience and paralysis. We can say: based on what I see, I will do this for now; I will look again on this date; I will change course if these conditions change. Such language is not weak. It is a way of keeping our promises to reality. It gives a decision a hinge, so that pride does not turn a first judgment into a prison.

The alternative is tempting: a confident story, a total prediction, an identity built around being the person who saw

it coming. The short-term reward is relief. The long-term cost is blindness. When the world changes, the rigid self has to defend yesterday's certainty rather than meet today's fact. A more durable confidence is quieter. It says not 'I cannot be wrong,' but 'I can be corrected without coming apart.'

The market may spend the next days trying to turn Wednesday's vote into a verdict about everything. That is its habit. We can resist the same habit in miniature. The facts may be incomplete; our responsibility is not. We can be exact about the evidence, gentle with the stakes, and willing to revise. That is the discipline of not knowing: not the absence of judgment, but judgment kept porous enough for truth to enter.

*The question to carry forward: where in your life would a little more honest uncertainty make your next decision more responsible?*

#### SOURCES NOTE

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